

Source study—The invasion of Persia

Alexander inherited the Macedonian throne and the position of commander-in-chief of the combined forces of the League of Corinth, and with it the war against Persia that Philip had declared in 337BC.

Early in 336BC an advance party of 10 000 troops under the command of Parmenio and Attalus had been sent across the Hellespont and had already liberated the coastal Greek city states as far south as Ephesus. The islands of Tenedos, Lesbos and Chios had also been freed from Persian control. This war was supposedly started as an act of revenge on the Persians for their sacrilege and destruction during Xerxes' invasion of Greece in 480–479BC.

Philip, no doubt, saw the war as a way to unify the Greeks and to keep them from attacking Macedonia while he invaded Asia Minor. The invasion would primarily benefit the Macedonians by asserting their control over Greece and protecting the Macedonian Empire against both Greeks and Persians at the same time. The capture of the royal Persian treasury at Sardis would make Philip richer and freeing the Greek city states of Ionia and the islands would encourage trade away from the Persians and towards the Greeks and Macedonians. He could also extend his empire.

The Greek states, despite making Philip the Strategos Autokrator, did not want to undertake the expedition. Philip used bribery, force and propaganda to make sure that the idea was accepted by most of the Greek states. Only Sparta refused to join in any actions of the League of Corinth. After Philip's death and the actions of Alexander at Thebes in 335BC, however, the main reason for Philip's expedition against Persia did not exist. Alexander had asserted his complete control over

the Greek states who, after the destruction of Thebes, were now scared.

- Why did Alexander decide to continue with Philip's planned invasion of Persia? Read the following extracts and decide for yourself.

Source 1—Plutarch, *Life of Alexander*, 5

Whenever he heard that Philip had captured some famous city or won an overwhelming victory, Alexander would take no pleasure at the news, but would declare to his companions, 'Boys, my father will leave nothing great or spectacular for you and me to accomplish to show the world'. He cared nothing for pleasure or wealth but only for deeds of valour and glory.'

Source 2—Arrian, *The Campaigns of Alexander*, 3.19

He burnt the palace of the Persian kings [Persepolis], though this was against the advice of Parmenio... Alexander's answer was that he wished to punish the Persians for their invasion of Greece; his present act was retribution for the destruction of Athens, the burning of temples, and all of the other crimes they had committed against the Greeks.

Source 3—Arrian, *The Campaigns of Alexander*, 2.14, a supposed letter to Darius

Your ancestors invaded Macedonia and Greece... You sent aid to the people of Perinthus in their rebellion against my father; Ochus sent an army into Thrace, which was part of our dominions; my father was killed by assassins whom, as you openly boasted in your letters, you yourself hired to commit the crime... you unjustly and illegally seized the throne... you sent Greeks false information about me in the hope of making them my enemies; you attempted to supply the Greeks with money... your agents corrupted my

friends... it was you [Darius] who began this quarrel.

Source 4—Plutarch, *Life of Alexander*, 5

On one occasion some Persian ambassadors arrived in Macedonia while Philip was away. Alexander received them. He talked to them and questioned them on matters such as the distances they had travelled by road, the nature of the country, the character of the Persian king, his experience in war, the military strength and prowess of the Persians. The ambassadors came away convinced that Philip's celebrated astuteness was as nothing compared to the adventurous spirit and lofty ambitions of his son.

Source 5—Arrian, *Anabasis*, 3.19–20

At Ecbatana, Alexander dismissed his Thessalian cavalry and the other allied contingents and ordered them back to the Aegean... Alexander himself also proposed to make for Parthia.

- List the reasons mentioned in the sources that explain why Alexander wanted to invade the Persian Empire.
- Go to a library and find out who Arrian and Plutarch were. When did they write their histories and biographies? How might this affect the reliability of their evidence?
- If the letter referred to by Arrian (Source 3) is genuine, where might he have got it from? What problem is created if the letter is a fake made up by Arrian?
- What do you think was the 'official' reason for the Persian expedition? Use evidence from the sources to support your answer.
- Source 5 refers to an event in 330BC (after the burning of Persepolis). Why is this event important to the question of why Alexander undertook the Persian expedition?